

USING SENSORY DESCRIPTION

Writing with all five senses



1 What is it?

Using Sensory Description

Sensory description uses **sight, sound, smell, taste and touch** — not just sight — to make a scene feel fully real and immersive to the reader.

sight + sound + smell + taste + touch

2 See it in action

Sound

The distant hum of traffic never quite faded, even at midnight.

Smell

The kitchen was thick with the smell of burnt toast and coffee.

Touch

The metal railing was icy and rough beneath her bare palm.

Taste

The soup was too salty, sharp and metallic on his tongue.



Good spot!

When writing a description, deliberately ask: "**which sense haven't I used yet?**" — sound, smell and touch are the most commonly forgotten.

FUN FACT

Smell is more strongly linked to memory than any other sense — which is why a single smell detail in a description can feel more powerful and evocative than several lines of visual description.

3 Why writers use it

Using Sensory Description help writers: ground a reader physically inside a scene rather than just showing it to them visually, create memorable, specific detail that feels real, and add atmosphere through senses that are often underused.

Sight is the sense writers reach for automatically — smell, sound and touch are used far less often, which makes them stand out more and often create the strongest, freshest descriptions.

4 Where you'll spot it

Food & travel writing

Taste and smell are used heavily to make an unfamiliar place or dish feel vivid and real to a reader who has never experienced it.

Horror fiction

Sound and touch (a creak, a cold draught) are often used to build dread more effectively than visual description alone.



Watch out!

Don't force all five senses into every description — one or two well-chosen, unexpected senses (smell, touch) usually beat cramming in all five for the sake of it.



Keep going!

Look for sensory detail beyond sight when analysing a text — a writer's choice to include a specific smell or sound is rarely accidental.

5 Quick recap

Uses sight, sound, smell,
taste, touch

Grounds the reader
physically in a scene

Often underused senses
feel freshest



Mfalme says...

Try describing a busy kitchen using only sound and smell — no visual description allowed at all — and notice how vivid it can still feel.